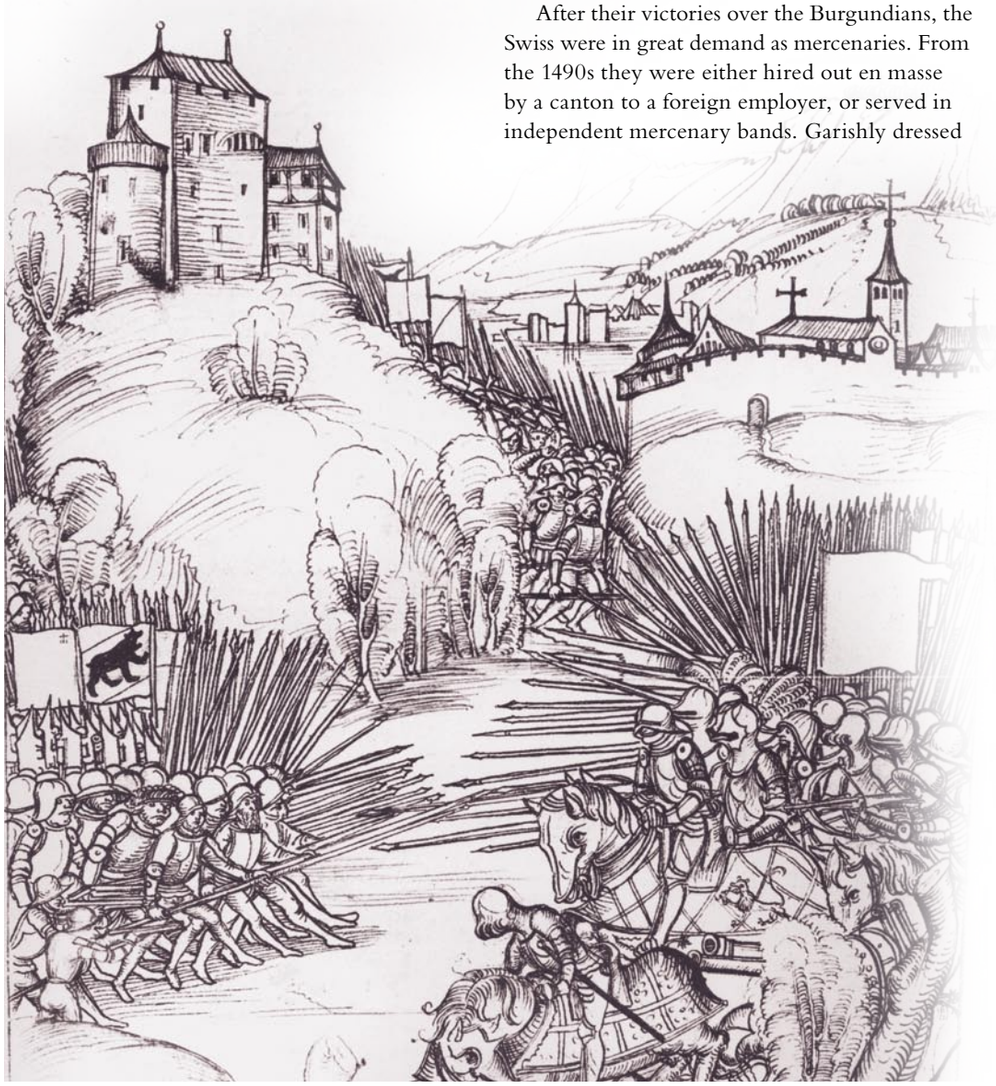
FOOT SOLDIERS OF THE RENAISSANCE

The Renaissance was a period when new technologies, in the form of firearms and cannon, had a profound impact on war. Yet simultaneously Europeans sought to learn from the classical world in warfare, as well as in art and architecture. The study of Ancient Greece and Rome convinced military thinkers that disciplined infantry were the key to success in battle, although attempts to recreate the order and discipline of the Roman army foundered upon the financial and organizational weaknesses of European states. Soldiers remained diversely clad, cynically mercenary, and dangerously prone to plunder and mutiny. Forces that successfully combined firearms with pike formations similar to the Greek phalanx had the edge on the battlefield.

SWISS PIKEMAN

The pikemen of the Swiss Confederation won an immediate name for themselves in 1476, when they trounced the mighty Burgundian army at the battles of Grandson and Murten. The Swiss foot soldiers were militia called up for service by their cantons (self-governing districts), and their style of fighting expressed the solidarity of their egalitarian society. Forming dense columns armed with pikes or halberds, they attacked shoulder-to-shoulder at a trot, overrunning their enemies before their cannon or cavalry could mount an effective riposte.

After their victories over the Burgundians, the Swiss were in great demand as mercenaries. From the 1490s they were either hired out en masse by a canton to a foreign employer, or served in independent mercenary bands. Garishly dressed in striped hose and puffed sleeves, they always sought to take the offensive, depending on the momentum of their massed columns to steamroller the opposition. A few crossbowmen or arquebusiers might accompany the pikes and halberds, but their role was peripheral.



Swiss triumph at Grandson, 1476
The battle turned when the Burgundian knights were surprised by the opportune arrival of a second force of well-disciplined Swiss pikemen and fled in disarray.

GERMAN COMPETITION

In the course of the Italian Wars of 1494 to 1525 the Swiss scored some notable successes, especially the defeat of the French at Novara in 1513. But other forces imitated their dense pike formation, particularly the Landsknecht mercenaries, who became the Swiss soldiers' bitterest enemies. And the limitations of Swiss tactics were revealed as armies learned how to combine pikes with a sophisticated use of firepower. At the battle of Bicocca in 1521 the Swiss ranks were decimated by fire from arquebuses and cannon after their initial "push of pike" had been blocked by field fortifications.

The Swiss, however, put in a lacklustre performance on the losing side at the battle of Pavia in 1525, which effectively ended their period of ascendancy among European infantry. They continued to fight as mercenaries in the service of the French monarchy, however, throughout the religious wars in the second half of the 16th century.



16TH-CENTURY SWISS HALBERD